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THE LONG ARM OF THE LASHKAR

Lashkar's commitment to the Kashmir jihad and obedience as a proxy enabled the group to expand vastly its military apparatus with the help of the army and ISI. Military officials provided more than merely arms and ammunition. They developed the group's training regimen, fought alongside its members at times and some even retired to join Lashkar's ranks. However, Lashkar's leaders aspired to do more than merely build a militant outfit and so they leveraged official Pakistani support to create a robust domestic and international infrastructure. By examining how Lashkar built its foundation in Pakistan and constructed networks abroad during the 1990s, this chapter becomes the base for understanding many of the group's future activities. While the focus is on Lashkar's development in these areas prior to 2001, more recent examples are occasionally used when they are useful for clarifying a point. It is helpful to begin by briefly outlining the group's organizational structure as it took shape during the 1990s.

Technically, Lashkar was the militant wing of MDI, which was a hierarchical commander-cadre organization, rather than one composed of discrete cells. A shura council made up of different department heads and others in leadership positions was established to oversee all operations. This Pakistan-based policy-making body made all major decisions about the group's missionary and military activities, which were then relayed to cadres in the field who were organized hierarchically. Different units were established to manage activities in various geographical locations in Pakistan. For example, one commander was responsible for activities in Lahore, with sub-unit heads operating under him. The group's hierarchy in Indian-administered Kashmir was modeled along a military chain of